

Gender Equity in Remote Work

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The widespread adoption of remote work has fundamentally altered professional life, particularly for women balancing paid employment and domestic responsibilities. Initially embraced as a response to pandemic-related disruptions, remote work has become a permanent fixture in many organizations. While it offers flexibility and autonomy, it also presents challenges that disproportionately affect women, including increased workloads, diminished professional visibility, and blurred boundaries between work and home life (de Laat, 2025; Shen & Zamani, 2025).

This shift has sparked an important debate: does remote work advance gender equity or reinforce existing inequalities? Advocates argue that remote work enables women to better manage caregiving responsibilities and achieve greater work-life integration, enhancing job satisfaction and retention (Schad, 2025). However, research suggests that these benefits may be offset by unintended consequences. Women often experience intensified domestic labor, fragmented work schedules, and reduced access to leadership opportunities, hindering long-term career advancement (Parry, 2025; de Laat, 2025).

The implications of this debate extend beyond individual experiences to broader organizational and societal outcomes. As remote and hybrid work models become increasingly common, it is essential to examine how they shape gender dynamics in the workplace. A nuanced understanding of these effects is necessary to develop policies that not only accommodate flexibility but also promote equity and inclusion.

This paper explores the complex relationship between remote work and gender equity by analyzing recent scholarly literature and presenting evidence-based recommendations for creating more supportive and fair remote work environments.

Remote Work as a Benefit for Women

Remote work has been praised for its ability to enhance women's professional and personal lives by offering greater flexibility and autonomy. Schad (2025) highlights that remote work improves work-life integration by eliminating commutes and allowing women to better align their schedules with caregiving responsibilities. Through qualitative interviews, Schad presents evidence that many women report increased job satisfaction and a sense of empowerment when working from home. These women feel more productive and in control of their time, contributing to a more positive work experience.

Complementing this perspective, Shen and Zamani (2025) examine how women actively engage in boundary management to navigate the demands of remote work. Their study finds that women tend to be more proactive than men in setting clear boundaries between work and home life, a strategy that enhances autonomy and reduces stress. However, the authors caution that these efforts are shaped by persistent gendered expectations, which often place the burden of managing both professional and domestic spheres disproportionately on women. Despite these challenges, the findings suggest that, with supportive organizational policies and personal agency, remote work can improve women's work experiences.

Remote Work as a Challenge for Women

Despite its benefits, remote work presents significant challenges that may undermine gender equity, particularly for women in dual-earner households. Parry (2025) introduces the concept of the "flexibility paradox," which describes how flexible work arrangements, though intended to support work-life balance, often reinforce traditional gender roles. Interviews with dual-earner parents reveal that fathers are more likely to have dedicated workspaces and uninterrupted work hours, while mothers frequently work in shared or high-traffic areas and during nonstandard hours to accommodate caregiving duties.

This spatial and temporal inequality leads to fragmented work time for women, reducing their productivity and visibility within organizations.

Similarly, de Laat (2025) highlights the phenomenon of “dual devotion,” where women are expected to fully commit to both professional and domestic roles. Her research finds that remote work can intensify overwork and emotional exhaustion as women struggle to meet the demands of both spheres without adequate structural support. These findings suggest that, without intentional intervention, remote work may exacerbate existing gender disparities by placing disproportionate burdens on women and limiting their opportunities for advancement.

Critical Evaluation

The scholarly literature reviewed presents a nuanced view of how remote work affects gender equity. While each source offers valuable insights, the strength and scope of evidence vary. Shen and Zamani (2025) provide a particularly robust analysis using mixed methods, combining quantitative data with qualitative interviews to examine gendered boundary management. Their findings align with Parry (2025), whose in-depth interviews with dual-earner couples offer compelling evidence of spatial and temporal inequalities in remote work environments.

In contrast, Schad (2025) presents a more anecdotal perspective, which, while insightful, lacks the empirical depth of other studies. De Laat (2025) offers a strong conceptual framework—“dual devotion”—that effectively captures the emotional and structural burdens remote workplaces on women, though it assumes a relatively uniform experience among professional women.

Several assumptions in these studies may limit their generalizability. Most notably, there is an implicit assumption that all women have access to supportive home environments, including private workspaces, reliable technology, and equitable domestic partnerships.

This overlooks the experiences of women in lower-income households, single-parent families, or those in less flexible job roles. Additionally, the focus on heterosexual, dual-earner couples (as in Parry, 2025) narrows the scope of analysis, excluding diverse family structures and caregiving arrangements.

Contextual factors such as family dynamics, job type, and organizational culture significantly influence how remote work is experienced. For example, women in leadership or knowledge-based roles may have more autonomy to manage boundaries, while those in administrative or client-facing positions may face stricter expectations.

Organizations with inclusive cultures and supportive policies are more likely to mitigate the negative effects of remote work on women's career progression.

These findings reinforce the conclusion that remote work is not inherently equitable. Its impact depends on how it is structured, supported, and culturally understood within organizations. Without intentional design and policy intervention, remote work may continue to reinforce traditional gender roles and limit women's professional advancement. This highlights the need for equity-focused strategies, outlined in the following recommendations.

Summary of Key Findings

Research indicates that remote work presents both opportunities and challenges for gender equity. While it offers flexibility that supports women's efforts to balance professional and domestic responsibilities (Schad, 2025; Shen & Zamani, 2025), it often reinforces traditional gender roles, leading to increased unpaid labor, fragmented work schedules, and reduced workplace visibility (Parry, 2025; de Laat, 2025).

Women are more likely to experience overwork and boundary violations, whereas men tend to benefit from more protected work time and space. These patterns suggest that, in its current form, remote work may inadvertently sustain or deepen existing gender inequalities.

Recommendations

To promote gender equity in remote work environments, organizations and policymakers should adopt a multifaceted approach:

- Implement structured hybrid work models that ensure equal access to leadership opportunities, mentorship, and high-visibility projects for both remote and in-office employees.
- Support boundary management by encouraging reasonable work hours, discouraging after-hours communication, and offering training on effective work-life integration strategies.
- Monitor workload distribution to ensure women, particularly in dual-earner households, are not disproportionately burdened with both professional and domestic responsibilities.
- Cultivate inclusive workplace cultures that challenge gendered assumptions about availability, productivity, and caregiving roles.
- Conduct data-driven evaluations of remote work policies to identify and address disparities in career progression, recognition, and overall well-being.

By implementing these strategies, remote work can evolve from a potential source of inequality into a powerful platform for inclusive and sustainable professional growth.

References

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